

When should public league-tabling be used as a way of encouraging government agencies, providers, policies or initiatives to perform better?

Public league-tabling consists of publishing comparative results from different organizations, agencies, providers, policies or initiatives. It is a type of 'benchmarking.' It certainly seems like a smart idea - harnessing the power of competition - and using public shame and accolades to improve agency, provider, policy or initiative performance. This When Public League-Tabling is Appropriate Checklist (F5) sets out the times when public league-tabling is, and is not, appropriate. The first issue with public league-tabling is the problem of whether the initiatives you are comparing are working with similar groups of people or units. If they are not, this may rule out league tabling, or it might be possible to measure improvement rather than just raw scores or standardize the results in some other way. The second issue is 'gaming' by interested parties. It may be theoretically possible to reduce gaming by introducing a third party to check results, but when comparing large numbers of institutions and collecting large amounts of data, this is often not affordable.

The third issue is reliability versus validity. A reliable measure is one where repeated measurement over multiple times, or by different raters, yield the same results. In contrast, a valid measure is one that truly measures what you want to measure. A naive push for reliability over validity almost always ends up in oversimplification: the easy to measure (e.g. academic scores) is preferred over the hard to measure (e.g. motivation, creativity, ability to get on with other people, or optimism about learning). High-stakes public league-tabling pushes the trade-off between reliability and validity towards reliability because more valid measures are often more subjective and expensive. The more comparisons are made public, the more disputes, if not litigation, there will be. And the more validity will be traded off against reliability to protect against litigation.

Lastly, public league-tabling can lead to 'client-flight' and institutional closure. This is particularly unfair if the league table system has major flaws, such as dissimilar people or units entering different initiatives. League tabling, which is not made public but used for initiative improvement, reduces the impact of these problems. A more nuanced consideration of results can occur in private discussions than the automatic public disapproval for those failing on the public league table.